horizons ’77

There is still room at the table.



EL FUTURO ES UNA ISLA

LE FUTUR EST UNE ÎLE

IL FUTURO È UN’ISOLA / DIE ZUKUNFT IST EINE INSEL

TENERIFE / EDICIÓN DEL CONGRESO / 1977

REVISTA INTERNACIONAL DE FUTUROS POSIBLES

NÚMERO 1 / 1977

horizons ’77

TENERIFE

ENGLISH · ESPAÑOL · FRANÇAIS · ITALIANO · DEUTSCH

The inhabited *island.*

Architecture, ocean, energy.
Notes towards life in 2027 and beyond.



TENERIFE / 2027

ESTUDIO PARA UN PAISAJE HABITADO

INTERNATIONAL CONFERENCE ON POSSIBLE FUTURES

Reports, drawings & conversations assembled at the close of the meeting.

200 PESETAS

LÁMINA 01

A landscape to inhabit.



A mountain above the clouds. A coast with work to do. Fifty years in which to reconsider the arrangements between them.

TENERIFE / ESTUDIO PARA UN PAISAJE HABITADO / 1977

EDITION NOTES / 2

Sources & contributors.

The cover landscape and the Bocacangrejo plate are newly generated images. The village scene is an interpretive reconstruction based on the creative brief, not a photograph of Alexander or a verified record of the village in 1977. "A village of hearts" is a metaphor inside the essay; no modern heart murals are placed in the period scene. The habitat section, route diagram and typographic plates are original graphics made for this edition. Paper texture, prices, folios and conference documents are part of the literary object, rather than evidence of a recovered publication.

The opening editorial is available in English, Spanish, French, Italian and German. Other papers include passages in their indicated languages. The seven-island atlas is a selected, schematic workshop map, not a complete geographic or navigation reference.

Geographic reference: Canary Islands tourism · Tenerife and Teide (hellocanaryislands.com).

Historical reference: Christopher Alexander archive · 1970 draft of The Timeless Way of Building (patternlanguage.com). Place-name reference: El Rosario municipality · Bocacangrejo (ayuntamientoelrosario.org).

Cousteau references: KCET / PBS SoCal · the November 1977 premiere (pbssocal.org); Ocean Futures Society · filmography (oceanfutures.org); The Cousteau Society · legacy and 1973 founding (cousteau.org).

The Maathai and Rahman contributions are original fictional conference reports. Their visits, interventions, conversations and influence on the island workshops are invented; no authentic quotations are represented. The Green Belt Movement began in 1977 under the National Council of Women of Kenya. Rahman's 1977 dismissal is described in his son's account. References: Green Belt Movement · history (greenbeltmovement.org); Ram Rahman · With Gropius and Habib Rahman (india-seminar.com).

Further marine reading: ECO · Meters Below Macaronesia (2024) (ecomagazine.com). This account concerns a 2023 expedition and the rebuilt Pisces VI; those operations are not placed in the magazine's 1977 setting. The coastal notebook's fish-farm swim and animal encounters are adapted personal memories, not a verified account of 1977 aquaculture.

Edition 01 / 2026.

Conceived and directed by Anselm, whose island recollections and editorial guidance shape this magazine. Made in collaboration with Codex, OpenAI's AI assistant, contributing research, drafting and translation, web design and implementation, visual direction and image-generation prompts, revisions and preview testing. This collaboration belongs to the 2026 making of the edition, not to its imagined 1977 conference.

EDITION NOTES / 1

On this edition.

Horizons '77 is an alternative-history magazine: an object imagined to have been assembled at the close of an international futures conference in Tenerife in 1977. The conference never took place.

The premise began in a 2025 conversation and this digital edition was made in October 2026. Its articles, editorial staff, documents and proposals are invented. Real island names and the presence of Teide anchor its geography; proposed settlements and transport connections belong to its alternative timeline.

Wangari Maathai, Habib Rahman, Terry Gilliam, Jane Goodall, Jacques-Yves Cousteau, Christopher Alexander, Paolo Soleri, Aldo Rossi and R. Buckminster Fuller appear as imagined contributors to the intellectual setting. No authentic quotations, documentary transcripts, actual designs or claims of historical attendance are represented. The essay attributed to Alexander, the fisherman's tour, the epiphany and the proposed machine-based fitness scheme are original fiction for this alternative timeline. Its influence on the completion of The Timeless Way of Building (1979) is imagined. Alexander's actual archive contains a draft from 1970; this story does not claim that his book or pattern thinking began in Tenerife. The phrase "what we build builds us in turn" is used here as an invented line in that fictional essay, not an authenticated quotation.

The horse page adapts a first-person recollection of an Andalusian stallion into the magazine's imagined period. The photograph was supplied for this edition; it is a contemporary photograph, not a recovered 1977 plate. The account is a reflection on agency and relationship, not documentation of a named training school or a technical training protocol.

The coastal notebook adapts first-person island recollections into the magazine's imagined period, rather than documenting a conference excursion. Its voices and encounters are not attributed to Alexander or other real delegates. The underwater ridge image is newly generated concept art. Montaña Amarilla and calima references: Tenerife tourism · Playa Montaña Amarilla (webtenerife.com); AEMET · Saharan dust intrusions (aemet.es). The fisherman's practical knowledge is part of the fictional scene, not a claim about his ancestry. For conquest and cultural survival: Museos de Tenerife · La conquista (museosdetenerife.org).

The Gilliam feature is an original fictional conference report, including the drawings, conversations and influence attributed to Tenerife. Jabberwocky (1977) was his first solo-directed feature; he co-directed Monty Python and the Holy Grail (1975) with Terry Jones. All remarks in quotation marks, observations and conference attendance are invented for this edition, not authenticated Gilliam quotations. The discussion of Dürer, Doré, Carroll and Fellini is an editorial reading of artistic affinities; Bosch and Bruegel are also discussed in Gilliam's later interviews. Historical reference: BFI · Jabberwocky (shop.bfi.org.uk); Museum of the Moving Image · Gilliam interview (movingimagesource.us).

The Goodall feature is an imagined conference report, including the conversations, drawings and Tenerife's influence on the institute. The Jane Goodall Institute was founded in the United States in 1977; research at Gombe began in 1960. Community-led conservation is presented as an aspiration within this alternative 1977, not a claim that later programmes already existed. No authentic quotation or actual attendance is represented. Historical references: Jane Goodall Institute · Jane's story (janegoodall.org); JGI Australia · timeline (janegoodall.org.au).

The Cousteau feature is an invented conference report: the visit, conversations, viewing-room inspiration and influence on his television and advocacy work are counterfactual. The Cousteau Society was founded in 1973; his habitat experiments, filmmaking and conservation commitments preceded this imagined meeting. The Cousteau Odyssey premiered on KCET on 22 November 1977, and Oasis in Space is a real 1977 series. No statement in the feature is an authenticated Cousteau quotation.

The underwater observatory plate is newly generated concept art, not an actual Cousteau habitat or recovered illustration.

NÚMERO 1 / TENERIFE / 1977

Sumario.

Papers, drawings and conversations assembled at the close of the conference.

An island is a beginning 5
Editorial / English

Una isla es un comienzo 7
Editorial / Español

Une île est un commencement 9
Éditorial / Français

Un'isola è un inizio 11
Editoriale / Italiano

Eine Insel ist ein Anfang 13
Editorial / Deutsch

The sea between us 15
Ocean habitats

A window long enough to care 17
Cousteau / Television notebook

The afternoon without a shore 19
Montaña Amarilla / Coastal notebook

A future of his own 21
An Andalusian stallion

A place for other lives 22
Goodall / Research & conservation

The future begins in a nursery 24
Maathai / Kenya, 1977

A town that learns the slope 26
Hillside settlements

The village that built us 28
Alexander / Bocacangrejo

ENGLISH / ESPAÑOL / FRANÇAIS / ITALIANO / DEUTSCH

NÚMERO 1 / TENERIFE / 1977

In this issue.

The common table, the working papers, the life between sessions.

The right to refuse 32
Rahman / The public trust

The sun has no accounts department 33
Island energy

The sky, by lift 35
Personal gliders & lift stations

Seven islands. Many futures. 37
Island atlas & annotations

Credit for things that last 39
Cooperative finance

A future with fingerprints 41
Gilliam / Film desk

Three seats at the table 43
Architectural portraits

Working programme 45
Working programme

A place at the table 46
Delegate credential

A future held in common 47
Cooperative prospectus

Before we leave the island 48
Closing editorial

On this edition. 50
On this edition

ENGLISH / ESPAÑOL / FRANÇAIS / ITALIANO / DEUTSCH

AL CIERRE / IN CHIUSURA / EN

Before we leave the island

Il reste une place à la table. Elle appartient à ceux qui ne sont pas encore arrivés, et à ceux dont nous avons oublié de demander l'avis. Gardons-la libre.

Ein gemeinsamer Tisch braucht einen freien Platz. Er gehört denen, die noch unterwegs sind, und denen, die wir bisher nicht gefragt haben. Vielleicht wird sich der wichtigste Beitrag erst im nächsten Brief finden. Wir lassen den Platz frei.

An open place at the table is not an unfinished arrangement. It is part of the arrangement. The next meeting will need new people, new arguments, and perhaps a slightly larger room. In the meantime there are letters to write, models to build and ordinary afternoons in which to begin.

Ci rivedremo. Il lavoro continua.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Correspondence for the next issue: papers, drawings, corrections and accounts of work in progress are welcome in English, Spanish, French, Italian or German. Please include a scale on all plans.

AL CIERRE / IN CHIUSURA / EN

Before we leave the island

The drawings are folded. The questions travel well.

The editors · Tenerife, 1977

1977 / 2027

1977 2027

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

The last morning is given over to small recoveries. A notebook returns to its owner. Someone finds a better word for a sentence translated three days ago. The large drawing of the archipelago comes down from the wall and, for a moment, everyone can see how pale a rectangle it has left.

We had arrived with futures in the plural. We leave with them still in the plural, but less separate. A discussion about housing now contains a water account. A transport drawing has acquired a shaded path. The prospectus for a cooperative has become interested in who will mend the roof. These are considerable changes for a few days at a table.

Beyond the terrace, the mountain has kept its own counsel. It has been useful to have something so large nearby which required neither an invitation nor a concluding statement. We have looked up from the plans often enough to remember that the island has an existence outside them.

El porvenir no cabe en una maleta. Nos llevamos unos dibujos, algunas direcciones y la costumbre de preguntar de otra manera. Las islas se quedan aquí, con sus habitantes, sus trabajos y sus propias conversaciones.

The year 2027 remains fifty years away. Some of the children whose lives we have discussed will then be older than their parents are today. We hope they will forgive our machinery where it is clumsy, and recognise our intentions where they are generous. Above all, we hope they will have had the opportunity to make better drawings.

EDITORIAL / EN

An island is a beginning

Before the future became familiar, it was a place we could travel to together.

The editors



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

The mountain is there before any of us. On the approach from the sea, Teide appears to belong to a different island: a second, higher country suspended above the first. Below it are the ordinary arrangements of living—roads, fields, washing, a bus taking the bend. We have come to discuss the year 2027. The bus has to get to Santa Cruz this afternoon.

This journal begins with that double view. We want the distance which permits an idea to grow, and the nearness which asks who will carry its materials uphill. An island offers both. Its limits can be seen, but its horizon cannot be reached. It receives the world without becoming the whole of it.

The conference proposed in these pages brings architecture into conversation with energy, transport, household life and money. Its real subject is permission: permission to imagine a settlement whose first drawing is not a road, a household whose first agreement is not a mortgage, a machine whose success is measured partly by the silence it leaves behind.

We work in English, Spanish, French, Italian and German. This is slower than working in one language, and we count the slowness among our resources. A word returns from the interpreter slightly changed. Someone discovers that what seemed inevitable was only customary. By lunch, even the word development has acquired several useful doubts.

EDITORIAL / EN

An island is a beginning

The islands are not vacant pages. Tenerife, La Palma, La Gomera, El Hierro, Gran Canaria, Fuerteventura and Lanzarote have names, landscapes, work and inhabitants. Our drawings must answer to them. A project which needs an empty island has already misunderstood the invitation.

In fifty years, many of the machines in this issue may look quaint. We hope the questions will not. How much ground should a person need? What can be held in common without making everyone alike? Can greater freedom of movement permit more places to be left alone?

We offer no finished picture of 2027. We offer a table large enough to unfold several pictures at once. The view from the table is very good. There is still work to do.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

1977 / 2027. Fifty years: enough time to grow a tree, raise a generation, and change the terms of a familiar argument. The editors ask that each proposal keep all three in view.

DOCUMENTO 03 · COOPERATIVA DEL PORVENIR

A future held in common

COOPERATIVA DEL PORVENIR

Certificado de participación

Propuesta para deliberación / Tenerife, 1977

Una participación en el cuidado de lo común.

Construcción / Conservación / Acceso

Draft circulated for discussion by the finance workshop. Terms of membership, maintenance and withdrawal are to be agreed before any subscriptions are accepted. The certificate is printed here with the working paper on patient capital and collective ownership.

See page 39.

DOCUMENTO 02 · CREDENCIAL DE DELEGADO

A place at the table

HORIZONS ’77 / TENERIFE

DELEGADO

NOMBRE / NAME

IDIOMAS / LANGUAGES

EN ES FR IT DE

ÁREA DE INTERÉS

EL FUTURO SE DISCUTE EN COMÚN.

A name, five languages and a field of interest. Between them, enough information to begin a conversation. Please keep the pass visible in the working rooms; at the common table, introductions are preferred.

EDITORIAL / ES

Una isla es un comienzo

Antes de que el futuro nos resultara familiar, era un lugar al que podíamos viajar juntos.

The editors



HORIZONS ’77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

La montaña está allí antes que cualquiera de nosotros. Al acercarnos por el mar, el Teide parece pertenecer a otra isla: un segundo país, más alto, suspendido sobre el primero. Abajo están los arreglos cotidianos de la vida: caminos, campos, ropa tendida, una guagua tomando la curva. Hemos venido a hablar del año 2027. La guagua tiene que llegar a Santa Cruz esta tarde.

Esta revista comienza con esa doble mirada. Queremos la distancia que permite crecer a una idea y la cercanía que pregunta quién subirá los materiales por la ladera. Una isla ofrece ambas cosas. Sus límites se ven, pero su horizonte no se alcanza. Recibe al mundo sin convertirse en el mundo entero.

El congreso propuesto en estas páginas pone la arquitectura en conversación con la energía, el transporte, la vida doméstica y el dinero. Su verdadero tema es el permiso: imaginar un pueblo cuyo primer dibujo no sea una carretera, un hogar cuyo primer acuerdo no sea una hipoteca, una máquina cuyo éxito se mida también por el silencio que deja.

Trabajamos en inglés, español, francés, italiano y alemán. Es más lento que trabajar en una sola lengua, y contamos esa lentitud entre nuestros recursos. Una palabra vuelve del intérprete ligeramente cambiada. Alguien descubre que lo que parecía inevitable era solamente habitual. Antes del almuerzo, incluso la palabra desarrollo ha adquirido varias dudas útiles.

EDITORIAL / ES

Una isla es un comienzo

Las islas no son páginas en blanco. Tenerife, La Palma, La Gomera, El Hierro, Gran Canaria, Fuerteventura y Lanzarote tienen nombres, paisajes, trabajo y habitantes. Nuestros dibujos deben responder ante ellos. Un proyecto que necesita una isla vacía ya ha entendido mal la invitación.

Dentro de cincuenta años, muchas máquinas de este número quizá parezcan ingenuas. Esperamos que las preguntas no. ¿Cuánto suelo necesita una persona? ¿Qué podemos compartir sin hacernos todos iguales? ¿Puede una mayor libertad de movimiento permitirnos dejar más lugares en paz?

No ofrecemos una imagen terminada de 2027. Ofrecemos una mesa lo bastante grande como para desplegar varias imágenes a la vez. La vista desde la mesa es muy buena. Todavía queda trabajo.

DOCUMENTO 01 · SECRETARÍA DEL CONGRESO

Working programme

09.00 · Sala Atlántico
Una isla es un comienzo.Opening assembly · English / español

10.30 · Taller I
Abitare il pendio.Compact settlements, shared kitchens and the right to a private room.

11.15 · Arbeitsgruppe / Taller II
Die bewohnte Landschaft.Gemeinsame Räume, Sonnenenergie und die Freiheit, weniger zu verbrauchen.

12.00 · Atelier III
Le soleil et la nuit.Energy, storage and the work of maintenance.

14.00 · Comedor
Almuerzo / déjeuner / pranzo / Mittagessen / lunch.One session without simultaneous interpretation.

15.30 · Taller del mar
The sea between us.Coastal habitats and proposed links to La Palma and La Gomera.

17.00 · Mesa común
Who owns the future?Land, credit and the conditions of membership.

19.00 · Terraza
Unfinished drawings. Open discussion.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Working languages: EN / ES / FR / IT / DE. Please return interpretation equipment at the end of the day.

CONVERSATIONS / CONVERSAZIONI / EN

Three seats at the table

No synthesis is announced at the end of the session. A synthesis would be attractive in the next issue, but the disagreement is presently doing useful work. Each seat changes what the others have to draw.

For the local respondents, the test is more immediate. Can the scheme be repaired here? Does it need land which is already in use? Who will look after someone who cannot climb the stairs? An international conference deserves its journey only if these questions can alter its conclusions.

The table remains open. In the best future imagined here, the visitors leave behind working drawings and take away some of their certainties.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Three editorial portraits; three scales of attention. The papers on settlement, habitat and energy take these questions back to the drawing table.

EDITORIAL / FR

Une île est un commencement

Avant de nous devenir familier, l'avenir était un lieu où nous pouvions voyager ensemble.

The editors



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

La montagne est là avant nous tous. À l'approche par la mer, le Teide semble appartenir à une autre île : un second pays, plus haut, suspendu au-dessus du premier. En bas, la vie suit son cours : routes, champs, linge qui sèche, autobus dans le virage. Nous sommes venus parler de l'an 2027. L'autobus doit arriver à Santa Cruz cet après-midi.

Cette revue commence par ce double regard. Nous voulons la distance qui permet à une idée de grandir et la proximité qui demande qui montera les matériaux sur la pente. Une île offre les deux. On voit ses limites sans atteindre son horizon. Elle accueille le monde sans devenir le monde entier.

Le congrès proposé dans ces pages fait dialoguer l'architecture avec l'énergie, les transports, la vie domestique et l'argent. Son véritable sujet est la permission : imaginer une ville dont le premier dessin ne serait pas une route, un foyer dont le premier accord ne serait pas un emprunt, une machine dont la réussite se mesurerait aussi au silence qu'elle laisse.

Nous travaillons en anglais, en espagnol, en français, en italien et en allemand. C'est plus lent que de travailler dans une seule langue, et nous comptons cette lenteur parmi nos ressources. Un mot revient de l'interprète légèrement changé. Quelqu'un découvre que ce qui semblait inévitable était seulement habituel. Avant le déjeuner, même le mot développement s'est enrichi de plusieurs doutes utiles.

EDITORIAL / FR

Une île est un commencement

Les îles ne sont pas des pages blanches. Tenerife, La Palma, La Gomera, El Hierro, Gran Canaria, Fuerteventura et Lanzarote ont des noms, des paysages, du travail et des habitants. Nos dessins doivent leur répondre. Un projet qui exige une île vide a déjà mal compris l'invitation.

Dans cinquante ans, bien des machines de ce numéro paraîtront peut-être désuètes. Nous espérons que les questions ne le seront pas. De combien de sol une personne a-t-elle besoin ? Que pouvons-nous partager sans devenir tous pareils ? Une plus grande liberté de mouvement permettra-t-elle de laisser davantage de lieux en paix ?

Nous ne proposons pas une image achevée de 2027. Nous proposons une table assez grande pour déplier plusieurs images à la fois. La vue depuis cette table est très belle. Il reste du travail.

CONVERSATIONS / CONVERSAZIONI / EN

Three seats at the table

Paolo Soleri, Aldo Rossi, R. Buckminster Fuller. Three ways of unfolding an island.

The editorial round table



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

Three names in the architecture notebook: Paolo Soleri, Aldo Rossi and R. Buckminster Fuller. Beside them, three drawings of the same island. One gathers buildings into a compact figure. One studies a square and the streets which remember it. One follows the lines out past the edge of the paper. We have arranged these working portraits around a common table.

SOLERI / THE COMPACT CITY. A town which grows upwards and inwards might release the land around it. The small distances inside the drawing are as important as its great outline: a child reaching a workshop, an older neighbour finding the common room, a garden close enough to be part of an ordinary day. The editors add a second sheet for food, water and the pleasures of being alone. The daily arrangements make the ambitious figure inhabitable.

ROSSI / THE TOWN THAT REMEMBERS. A harbour stair, a shaded threshold, the outline of a square: a town contains things which continue while its inhabitants change. What would an entirely new settlement remember? The question sends the workshop back to its entrances and gathering places. A room below the sea might still need a recognisable address. The next drawing begins at the scale of a person arriving on foot.

FULLER / THE LARGER SYSTEM. The house is an arrangement of materials and energy whose story begins long before anyone turns a key. Its lines lead towards ships, mines, power stations and replacement parts. A light structure may have a surprisingly large shadow. The editors unfold a sheet which is inconveniently larger than the table. There is pleasure in finding that a better account of the whole can suggest a more generous use of each part.

CINÉMA / WORLDS IN THE MAKING / EN

A future with fingerprints

The joke has a serious ancestry. A court fool can tell a king what an adviser cannot; carnival borrows the crown and discovers how readily it fits a donkey. Here the elevated hope is that a better arrangement will make better lives. Gilliam keeps introducing the person who enjoys being in charge of the arrangement. His own drawing is no exception. The official in its doorway bears a suspicious resemblance to its author.

At the housing table, the communal kitchen becomes a scene. There must be somewhere to put a hot pan while another person searches for the cupboard. The perfect terrace acquires a chair which belongs to somebody rather than to the composition. Gilliam tips the perspective a little; a room which seemed quite settled becomes uncertain. "You will still need somewhere to sulk," he observes. The private room survives the afternoon's deliberations.

For all the mischief, he stays with the drawings. He wants to know how the glider lands, how the underwater window is cleaned, what the village sounds like after supper. These are questions from someone who would like to enter the picture. As the sheets are packed, a few of their inhabitants have ceased to stand politely at the edge. One is busy. Another has moved a chair. The future has acquired somebody capable of laughing at it from inside.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

FROM THE FILM DESK / 1977. Three views of the same proposal: the room before its inhabitants arrive; the room in use; the room being repaired. Keep all three in the drawing set.

EDITORIAL / IT

Un'isola è un inizio

Prima di diventare familiare, il futuro era un luogo verso cui potevamo viaggiare insieme.

The editors



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

La montagna è lì prima di tutti noi. Arrivando dal mare, il Teide sembra appartenere a un'altra isola: un secondo paese, più alto, sospeso sopra il primo. Sotto ci sono le cose quotidiane della vita: strade, campi, bucato, un autobus che affronta la curva. Siamo venuti a discutere dell'anno 2027. L'autobus deve arrivare a Santa Cruz questo pomeriggio.

Questa rivista comincia con quel doppio sguardo. Vogliamo la distanza che permette a un'idea di crescere e la vicinanza che chiede chi porterà i materiali su per il pendio. Un'isola offre entrambe. Se ne vedono i limiti, ma non se ne raggiunge l'orizzonte. Accoglie il mondo senza diventare il mondo intero.

Il convegno proposto in queste pagine mette l'architettura in dialogo con l'energia, i trasporti, la vita domestica e il denaro. Il suo vero tema è il permesso: immaginare un insediamento il cui primo disegno non sia una strada, una casa il cui primo accordo non sia un mutuo, una macchina il cui successo si misuri anche dal silenzio che lascia.

Lavoriamo in inglese, spagnolo, francese, italiano e tedesco. È più lento che lavorare in una sola lingua, e contiamo questa lentezza fra le nostre risorse. Una parola ritorna dall'interprete leggermente cambiata. Qualcuno scopre che ciò che sembrava inevitabile era soltanto abituale. Prima di pranzo, persino la parola sviluppo ha acquistato diversi dubbi utili.

EDITORIAL / IT

Un'isola è un inizio

Le isole non sono pagine bianche. Tenerife, La Palma, La Gomera, El Hierro, Gran Canaria, Fuerteventura e Lanzarote hanno nomi, paesaggi, lavoro e abitanti. I nostri disegni devono rispondere a loro. Un progetto che richiede un'isola vuota ha già frainteso l'invito.

Fra cinquanta anni molte macchine di questo numero potranno sembrare ingenue. Speriamo che non lo sembrino le domande. Di quanto suolo ha bisogno una persona? Che cosa possiamo tenere in comune senza diventare tutti uguali? Una maggiore libertà di movimento può permetterci di lasciare più luoghi in pace?

Non offriamo un'immagine compiuta del 2027. Offriamo un tavolo abbastanza grande per aprire più immagini insieme. La vista dal tavolo è molto bella. C'è ancora lavoro da fare.

CINÉMA / WORLDS IN THE MAKING / EN

A future with fingerprints

Terry Gilliam, after Jabberwocky, among the drawings of tomorrow.

Lucien Morel · Film desk

FILM DESK / THREE VIEWS OF A POSSIBLE ROOM

1	2	3
BEFORE	IN USE	IN REPAIR

Allow room for the people.

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

The future has been drawn very carefully. The floor is clean, the chairs agree with one another, and the person beside the window appears to have no possessions which the architect has not approved. Terry Gilliam studies the perspective. "Where do they keep the things they are ashamed of?" A cupboard is added. It is the first amendment of the morning.

He comes to Tenerife in the year of Jabberwocky, his first feature as sole director after sharing Monty Python and the Holy Grail with Terry Jones in 1975. He is finding a voice outside the familiar company, with no settled kingdom of his own to defend. Among the grave pronouncements, he acquires something like the fool's privilege: permission to touch the robes and ask what is underneath.

There is an old company behind this young disturbance. Bosch and Bruegel crowd the world with appetites which no orderly scheme quite contains; the engraved worlds of Dürer and Doré give even the fantastic a formidable material weight. Carroll makes authority ridiculous by allowing its rules to speak at length. Fellini lets the procession swell until dignity and grotesquerie share a face. In Gilliam's crowded frames, the grand design must make room for the body, and the body has brought its lunch.

At the transport table, a tower raises the little aircraft to its departure height. Gilliam admires the principle, then draws a second tower beside it. "The office which gives you permission to use the first one." The engineer laughs and asks whether the office needs a lift. Within minutes the margin contains a much larger building than the original station. Somebody writes ADMINISTRATION across it in very small letters.

ECONOMY / ECONOMIA / EN

Credit for things that last

There are difficult questions. How does a resident leave? Who inherits a right of use? What prevents a committee from becoming a landlord with longer meetings? The workshop prints these questions beside the prospectus, rather than leaving them for the small type.

A draft subscription certificate appears on the table after lunch. Its first promise is a right to take part in decisions. Its second is a duty to keep the place in good repair. A delegate proposes that the annual meeting begin with a tour of everything which has worn out. This attracts an unexpected amount of support from the architects.

Creative finance is useful when it makes durable work possible. If it merely makes the liabilities harder to find, we should return it to the drawing office. The island is not improved by moving a debt from the beach to the horizon.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

The draft certificate is reproduced among the loose leaves. No subscriptions are to be accepted before the terms of membership, maintenance and withdrawal have been agreed.

EDITORIAL / DE

Eine Insel ist ein Anfang

Bevor uns die Zukunft vertraut wurde, war sie ein Ort, zu dem wir gemeinsam reisen konnten.

The editors



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

Der Berg ist vor uns allen da. Vom Meer aus scheint der Teide zu einer anderen Insel zu gehören: einem zweiten, höher gelegenen Land, das über dem ersten schwebt. Darunter liegen die alltäglichen Dinge des Lebens: Straßen, Felder, Wäsche, ein Bus in der Kurve. Wir sind gekommen, um über das Jahr 2027 zu sprechen. Der Bus muss heute Nachmittag in Santa Cruz sein.

Diese Zeitschrift beginnt mit diesem doppelten Blick. Wir suchen die Entfernung, in der eine Idee wachsen kann, und die Nähe, die danach fragt, wer das Material den Hang hinauftragen wird. Eine Insel bietet beides. Ihre Grenzen sind sichtbar, ihr Horizont bleibt unerreichbar. Sie empfängt die Welt, ohne selbst die ganze Welt zu werden.

Die Konferenz auf diesen Seiten bringt Architektur mit Energie, Verkehr, dem häuslichen Leben und dem Geld ins Gespräch. Ihr eigentliches Thema ist die Freiheit, sich etwas vorzustellen: eine Siedlung, deren erste Zeichnung keine Straße ist; einen Haushalt, dessen erste Vereinbarung keine Hypothek ist; eine Maschine, deren Erfolg sich auch an der Stille misst, die sie hinterlässt.

Wir arbeiten auf Englisch, Spanisch, Französisch, Italienisch und Deutsch. Das geht langsamer als in einer einzigen Sprache, und wir rechnen diese Langsamkeit zu unseren Möglichkeiten. Ein Wort kommt vom Dolmetscher ein wenig verändert zurück. Jemand entdeckt, dass etwas, das unvermeidlich schien, lediglich üblich war. Bis zum Mittagessen hat selbst das Wort Entwicklung einige nützliche Zweifel hinzugewonnen.

EDITORIAL / DE

Eine Insel ist ein Anfang

Die Inseln sind keine leeren Seiten. Tenerife, La Palma, La Gomera, El Hierro, Gran Canaria, Fuerteventura und Lanzarote haben Namen, Landschaften, Arbeit und Bewohner. Unsere Zeichnungen müssen ihnen gerecht werden. Ein Vorhaben, das eine leere Insel braucht, hat die Einladung bereits missverstanden.

In fünfzig Jahren werden manche Maschinen in diesem Heft vielleicht sonderbar wirken. Wir hoffen, dass es den Fragen anders ergeht. Wie viel Boden braucht ein Mensch? Was können wir gemeinsam besitzen, ohne alle gleich zu werden? Kann größere Bewegungsfreiheit dazu beitragen, mehr Orte unberührt zu lassen?

Wir bieten kein fertiges Bild des Jahres 2027. Wir bieten einen Tisch, der groß genug ist, um mehrere Bilder zugleich darauf auszubreiten. Die Aussicht von diesem Tisch ist sehr schön. Es bleibt noch Arbeit.

ECONOMY / ECONOMIA / EN

Credit for things that last

A prospectus for patient money and impatient people.

Carlo Bellini · Economics correspondent

COOPERATIVA DEL PORVENIR

A share in the long view.

CONSTRUCTION / MAINTENANCE / ACCESS

PROPOSED SUBSCRIPTION / 1977

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

A house lasts longer than an election, a water main longer than a sales brochure. Yet both must negotiate with money that would prefer to return by Friday. The finance workshop begins with this mismatch and attempts a modest correction: match the term of the obligation to the useful life of the thing.

The proposed island development trust would hold selected land and shared infrastructure. Residents would hold rights of use and participation under published rules. Membership would not be a promise that land values must always rise. A place could become better without becoming less affordable to the people who made it so.

The prospectus separates three funds. The first pays for construction. The second pays for maintenance from the first day, however new the paint looks. The third supports access for households whose work is essential but whose income is irregular. None of these funds can be replenished indefinitely by drawing a more attractive cover.

Il credito è un accordo sul tempo. Se finanziamo una piazza, dobbiamo sapere chi può usarla, chi la cura e chi può cambiare le regole. Il rendimento non può essere l'unica frase del contratto.

ATLAS DEL PORVENIR / ANOTACIONES

Each island has a name.

La Palma
A research exchange and a proposed passenger connection to Tenerife. The open Atlantic becomes a landscape to learn together.

El Hierro
The workshop proposes small-scale energy and water accounting before any large new infrastructure. A small experiment can be an ambitious beginning.

La Gomera
A shared-vessel study asks whether better connections can reduce the pressure to build new roads. Quiet and access are considered together.

Tenerife
The host island: terraced settlements on a disturbed coastal site, a small habitat, and an energy cooperative. Teide is the geographic anchor.

Gran Canaria
A workshop on repair, marine transport and shared fabrication. A proposed connection to Tenerife includes the workshops and spare parts that make a route a service.

Fuerteventura
The wind-and-shade notebook begins with building orientation and water demand. The first design material is the afternoon shade.

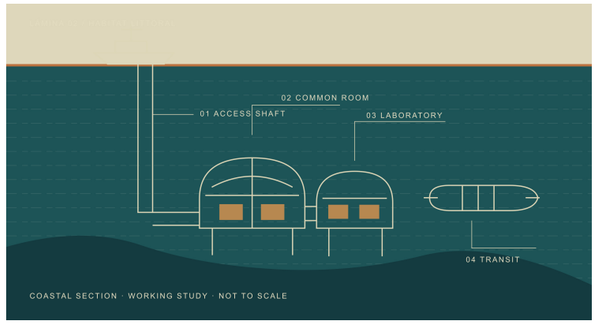
Lanzarote
A conservation session considers compact living alongside volcanic terrain. The proposed intervention is a limit on development before it is a new building.

OCEAN / OCEANO / EN

The sea between us

Habitats, submarine trams, and the right to remain a visitor.

Marina Valdés · Ocean workshop



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

The first drawing showed a line between islands. The second showed what the line had crossed. Between them lay the beginning of a more interesting proposal. The Atlantic was not an inconvenient interval to be removed. It was a place with its own depth, weather and life.

The ocean workshop unfolds a small habitat close to the coast of Tenerife: a research room, a common room, sleeping compartments and an access shaft rising towards a surface vessel. Amber lamps pick out the table beneath the dome. Beyond the windows, daylight changes slowly into blue. A school could spend an afternoon here; a marine biologist might stay a season. The sea would become a neighbour with whom we were finally on speaking terms.

A second drawing sends a submarine tram towards La Palma. The windows belong to the shallow approach; out in deep water the journey becomes a quieter passage through darkness. In the common carriage, a reading lamp stands above each pair of seats. The designer has drawn a small shelf for a cup. We recognise this as the moment when an extraordinary machine begins to imagine an ordinary passenger.

The route sheet opens towards La Gomera and Gran Canaria, making the archipelago legible as a constellation of meeting places. Three studies accompany it: an independent submarine vessel, a suspended guideway and an undersea link. The engineers have kept them on separate sheets. There is much still to learn about the depths between islands; the drawing office has left a generous margin for the ocean to answer.

OCEAN / OCEANO / EN

The sea between us

A note from the architecture table asks what would make a submerged room recognisable as part of a town. A table, perhaps. A place to arrive. A light which is not merely an indicator. The corridor is revised to end in a small square, and for the first time the habitat looks like somewhere one might arrange to meet a friend.

Abitare non significa occupare tutto. Il mare non è un terreno in attesa di edifici. Una piccola stanza può insegnarci più di una città sommersa, se ci permette di osservare, ascoltare e poi tornare a riva.

To inhabit does not mean to occupy everything. A room beneath the surface might teach the visitor restraint: how to receive air, how to account for heat, how to leave something undisturbed. We should be suspicious of any habitat advertised as independence from nature. Every pipe in the drawing says otherwise.

At the end of the session, the submarine route and the habitat are pinned beside a drawing of an ordinary harbour. They look less like rival futures than three different ways of arriving. Above them someone has written: la costa continúa. The coast continues. It is an excellent beginning for a transport plan.

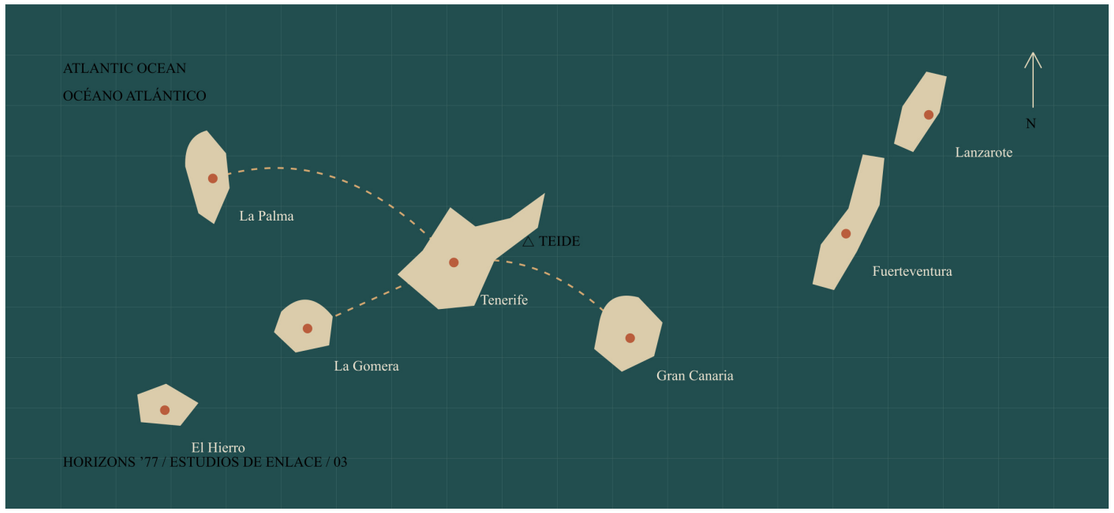
DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Lámina 02. Coastal habitat section; working study, not to scale. The route papers distinguish independent vessels, guided systems and tunnels. Bathymetric and engineering studies are to follow.

TRANSPORT WORKSHOP / ROUTE STUDY 03

Seven islands. Many futures.

The space between places is a place too.



ISLAS CANARIAS / SCHEMATIC GEOGRAPHY / PROPOSED LINKS

La Palma, La Gomera, Tenerife, Gran Canaria. Every line is a question. Notes from each island follow on page 38.

MOVEMENT / MOBILITÉ / EN

The sky, by lift

Les stations ne vendent pas le vent; elles fournissent de la hauteur. Un premier ascenseur, un vol plané, puis un second ascenseur si le voyage continue. Le ciel devient un réseau de départs, de descentes et de nouvelles possibilités. La correspondance se prend au rez-de-chaussée.

The energy has not disappeared. Raising an aircraft takes work, and the air gradually receives the energy of its descent. The proposed economy lies in efficient fixed lifting equipment, lighter craft and less machinery carried through every mile of the journey. The workshop asks for an account of the whole trip, including the lifts and the return of aircraft. A tower must earn its place in that account as well as in the skyline.

Wind and terrain give the network its actual shape. A station must be within a safe glide of the next receiving point, with room for an alternative landing; headwinds shorten the reach. A mountainside is no substitute for a clear approach. The island plan therefore begins with land routes and trials between neighbouring stations. Lines towards La Gomera, La Palma and Gran Canaria await a much more demanding study of weather, distance and the sea below.

The drawings have an unexpected quietness. A visitor arrives at a tower with a small machine, rises above the roofs and spends the afternoon's height on the journey home. At a distant station there may be a brief wait for the next lift. The waiting room has been given a generous window. For once, the view and the means of transport have been designed together.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Flight study 05. The sawtooth line records powered ascent at each tower followed by an unpowered glide. It is a principle diagram, not a surveyed route or a performance claim. Compare total lifting energy, craft mass and weather margins before choosing station spacing.

CINÉMA / THE LIVING SEA / EN

A window long enough to care

Jacques-Yves Cousteau leaves Tenerife with the beginnings of a new odyssey.

Lucien Morel · Television notebook



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

At the ocean workshop, the most consequential drawing was not the submarine tram. It was a room with somewhere to sit. Beyond its curved window lay a stretch of seabed; inside, a bench, a table and the possibility of remaining. Cousteau stayed beside this drawing after the discussion had moved on. By the end of the conference it had become the first scene in a new television proposal.

He had arrived with a lifetime of looking beneath the surface already behind him. His underwater-house experiments had made the seabed a place where people could work and remain. His films had brought that world into homes far from any coast. What Tenerife offered was a different company around the window: architects discussing the shape of attention, painters interested in the changing light, musicians asking what could be heard when the room fell quiet.

The proposed habitat would receive small groups of artists, naturalists and neighbours. Its viewing platforms were places to return to, at different hours, until the apparently empty patch of rock became a place of recognisable lives. A fish which crossed the window each morning could become more than an example of its species. The observer might begin to notice its absences. The architecture had provided enough time for a relation to form.

This was the impulse Cousteau carried into the new series, The Cousteau Odyssey. The camera would still travel with Calypso, follow a difficult dive and enter the mysteries of a wreck. But the conference had given the journey another centre: the patient encounter, and the passage from admiration to affection. A television set could become a temporary room beneath the water, with a whole family gathered at its window.

CINÉMA / THE LIVING SEA / EN

A window long enough to care

On peut montrer la mer comme une succession de merveilles. On peut aussi laisser au spectateur le temps de rencontrer une vie. Une fenêtre, un peu de silence, le retour d'un même poisson: l'étonnement devient attention, puis attachement. Le film commence lorsque nous cessons de demander à la mer de nous distraire.

In the viewing-room study, art was part of learning to stay. A drawing took longer than a glance. A composer listening through a hydrophone might hear a pattern which the visitor had dismissed as background. The shared work could travel back to the surface as a film, a score, a page of marks. The few people who descended would make something for the many who could not. Compassion might pass through those forms without becoming an instruction.

The Cousteau Society, founded in 1973, gives this new resolve a life beyond the screen. The work of witnessing pollution, making it visible and pressing for its reduction belongs beside the work of making a film. The short films of Oasis in Space place the sea within a larger living world. Here in Tenerife, these strands have found a common table. The habitat is an observatory, a studio and a small school of concern; the broadcasts carry its windows into other rooms.

The hospital ship Britannic and other submerged histories will draw viewers towards the new odyssey. Around those histories, the sea continues its own affairs. A wreck is also a place where creatures shelter, feed and begin again. The workshop's departing thought is that a film can hold both kinds of attention: the grief and curiosity of human memory, and the independent lives which have made a home beside it. The sea need not become useful to us before it deserves our care.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

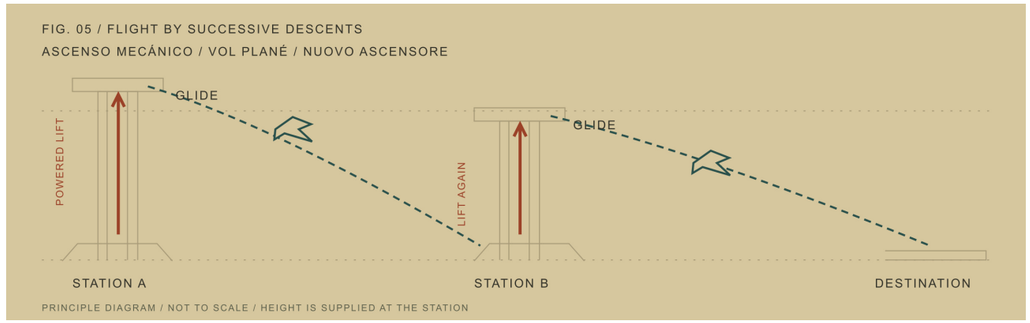
TELEVISION NOTICE / 22 NOVEMBER 1977. The Cousteau Odyssey begins on KCET. From the workshop notebook: let a scene last long enough for its inhabitants to stop being scenery.

MOVEMENT / MOBILITÉ / EN

The sky, by lift

Skyscraper stations, personal gliders, and the useful art of coming down.

Inés Duarte · Transport workshop



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

The journey begins in a lift. A small personal aircraft rolls into a cradle at the foot of a slender skyscraper station; its occupant stays beside it as the doors close. Above the town, a departure gallery opens to the wind. The wings unfold, the craft is released, and the passenger sets off towards a destination lower in the sky. Most of the journey is a descent.

This is the transport workshop's proposal for conserving energy in personal flight. Instead of asking each aircraft to carry the machinery and fuel for its own climb, a fixed electrical installation raises craft and passenger together. Height becomes a service supplied by the station. The light aircraft then spends that height in a long, controlled glide. What is heavy stays in the tower; what travels can be lighter.

The station is drawn as a skyscraper with a very particular top floor. Beneath the departure gallery are the lifting machinery, inspection rooms and a weather office. At ground level, a receiving court allows the wings to fold before the next ascent. A person might own the aircraft while using the lifting station in common, much as a private boat uses a public harbour.

A nearby journey needs one ascent and one glide. A farther journey is a chain of descents. The traveller glides to the receiving court of a second tower, is lifted again, and leaves at a fresh altitude. Across a large district there might be two intermediate ascents before the final landing. On the route drawing, distance is bought in successive parcels of height.

ENERGY / ÉNERGIE / EN

The sun has no accounts department

Die Sonne liefert keine fertige Gesellschaft. Zwischen dem Kollektor auf dem Dach und dem warmen Wasser in der Küche liegen Rohre, Speicher und die Arbeit vieler Hände. Eine gemeinsame Energieversorgung könnte mehr sein als eine technische Anlage: eine tägliche Übung darin, voneinander abhängig zu sein, ohne einander die Freiheit zu nehmen.

The common ledger records heat, electricity, water and work separately. It does not allow an impressive electrical total to conceal waste in the hot-water circuit. Nor does it count unpaid care as a limitless source of renewable labour. The person who cleans a collector should appear in the accounts beside the collector.

The proposed energy cooperative sells a service rather than a promise of endless consumption. Its members have a claim on reliable light, refrigeration and essential pumping, together with a vote on future investment. There is disagreement over the workshop's evening opening hours. This is encouraging: at last the discussion concerns something people actually need.

If 2027 brings a less conspicuous energy system, it may be because the architecture has learned to ask for less. The best machine on the hillside could be a shaded room in which nobody needs to turn anything on.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

The energy ledger is to be circulated in four columns: generation, storage, demand and maintenance. The last column must include the work, not simply the parts.

CUADERNO DE COSTA / FROM THE WATER / EN

The afternoon without a shore

Montaña Amarilla. Notes on becoming, for a while, part of the water.

From a visitor's notebook



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

At Playa de Montaña Amarilla the light was in pieces on the waves. We swam out over the submerged volcanic ridge, looking down through the glitter. Every so often I folded at the waist and went beneath it. Twenty or thirty feet below, barracuda were lined up near the bottom, holding their places in the water. From above there had been only the flashing surface. Down here there were lives going on.

I stayed out with my friends for the whole afternoon. We never went back to shore. We floated, swam, dived, came up for breath and went down again. After a while the beach ceased to be the place to which the afternoon belonged. We were basically fishes with flippers and goggles. The strange part was how ordinary this began to feel.

Another time we slipped beneath the suspended cages of a fish farm, enjoying the small naughtiness of going a little beyond where we were meant to be. Large, lazy turtles moved through the water, and sea rays passed with that slow movement which scarcely seems to require an effort. A dolphin came over to us. It seemed to have arrived for the purpose of meeting us. We had gone there to look down into the water and found ourselves being looked at in return. For a little while there was no better account of the encounter than this: an animal had come to see who was there.

There were small whales, too, on other swims, and dives in quieter backwaters where the creatures were tiny and unfamiliar. Some seemed barely more than a translucent edge or a minute arrangement of moving parts. I did not have their names. They had the complete strangeness of something imagined, and yet there they were, quite occupied with being alive.

CUADERNO DE COSTA / FROM THE WATER / EN

The afternoon without a shore

The coast above the water could feel just as improbable. Houses stood one above another against the cliffs, finding a ledge, making a stair, borrowing a little shelter from the rock. From the sea, their white walls belonged to the dark face of the island in a way no flat plan could show. A person carrying something down to a boat had to negotiate the actual mountain, step by step.

Elsewhere the island changed its appearance so completely that it seemed we had travelled much farther than we had. Yellow stone, black rock, bare slopes, green folds of land; a mountain appearing above a layer of cloud. The differences were close enough to hold in a day, but they did not become less vivid through being close. The island kept teaching the eye to begin again.

Then there were the calima days. Dust came across from Africa and altered the light. The horizon lost its edge; distances which had seemed certain became difficult to read. Fine powder settled where we had expected clean air. The island was not as separate as its outline on the map. A continent we could not see had entered the room.

When I think of the long afternoon at Montaña Amarilla, I remember the small return to breathing after each dive, and the barracuda still below us when we went back down. They had not come to provide an experience. We had spent a few hours inside the place where they lived. Even after we took off our flippers, the sensation of belonging to the water stayed with us. Walking on land felt, for a little while, like the unusual thing.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

CUADERNO DE COSTA. Above and below the same water: the glittering surface, the submerged ridge, the lives which continue when the swimmer comes ashore.

ENERGY / ÉNERGIE / EN

The sun has no accounts department

An island energy ledger, with a column for the night.

Lucien Morel · Technical correspondent

FIG. 04 / THE COMMON LEDGER

01	02	03	04
GENERATION	STORAGE	DEMAND	MAINTENANCE

A column for the night. A place for the person who repairs it.

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

At noon the proposed energy diagram looks generous. Sunlight arrives on roofs, collectors warm water, and a row of small workshops takes its place beneath a shared electrical line. By midnight the same diagram has become a test of honesty. Which stores are full? Which tasks can wait? Who is responsible when a pump stops?

The energy workshop refuses a single victorious machine. It draws solar heat for water, photovoltaic electricity as an ambitious developing option, wind where appropriate, and storage whose cost and materials must be counted. Conservation has a place before generation: shade is a piece of equipment which is unusually quiet.

Geothermal exploration appears as a question mark beneath the volcanic landscape. A volcano on the horizon does not establish a useful reservoir at a convenient depth. The proposal calls for investigation, ecological scrutiny and a public account of failed wells as well as successful ones. A map of heat is not yet a power station.

L'énergie commune demande une politique de l'entretien. Le soleil peut être gratuit; les conduites, les accumulateurs et le travail ne le sont pas. Il faut décider ensemble ce qui doit fonctionner sans interruption, et ce qui peut attendre le matin.

DELHI / THE PUBLIC TRUST

The right to refuse

Habib Rahman, Delhi, and the public architect's difficult signature.

From the public works desk

There is a blank space at the bottom of every proposal which interests Habib Rahman. It is where somebody must eventually sign. The conference has filled many sheets with possible futures. Who is prepared to withhold a signature when a proposal should not be built?

This year his contract as secretary of the Delhi Urban Art Commission has been terminated. He had opposed official proposals, including putting a Gandhi statue beneath the empty imperial canopy at India Gate and placing public conveniences where they would obstruct the southern entrance to Jama Masjid. A commission intended to scrutinise the city had encountered the inconvenience of scrutiny.

Rahman comes to the island with the experience of building public housing and institutions for an independent India. He has worked with restricted budgets, urgent needs and the conviction that modern architecture should serve ordinary life. He does not regard a large public undertaking as necessarily an enemy. He knows how much depends on who can question it.

At the transport table, his intervention takes the form of a space left on the route plan. Before the line is approved, the people whose ground it crosses must be able to object. The objection must have somewhere to go, and the person hearing it must possess more than a ceremonial chair. A beautiful diagram offers little protection if every decision has already been made.

The finance workshop adds a question to its draft constitution: can the person entrusted with examination refuse the project without losing the means to examine the next one? It is a less attractive sentence than the prospectus title. For the moment, nobody volunteers to remove it.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

Who may object? Who must listen? Who can refuse?

VIDA COMPARTIDA / WORKING TOGETHER

A future of his own

An Andalusian stallion, brought from Seville. Notes on learning to ask.

From an island notebook



He had come from Seville, a beautiful Andalusian stallion, formally schooled in the Spanish discipline. He knew how to answer a person's request with an exact movement. Against Teide, his pale body was always startling: this gentle, strong animal in front of a mountain which belonged to another measure of time.

The work then became a kind of untraining, followed by learning together again. We wanted his willingness to matter. An invitation had to leave room for an answer we had not already chosen. If he paused, or turned away, something in our plan could change. His future was to become more his own, rather than a sequence of beautifully executed decisions made for him.

Once he threw me. I became tangled in a lead rope and he dragged me around the arena. The animal I knew as gentle was also immensely strong.

Afterwards, that contrast remained with me. Affection did not make him small, and gentleness did not make his strength disappear. There was another body here, with its own alarm, movement and intention.

To work with him was to attend to that other life. The lesson did not end when a movement had been performed correctly. It continued in whether he chose to remain with us, whether an encounter left more room for trust, whether we could let an unfinished exercise be enough for the day. We were learning to recognise a decision which was not ours.

I kept returning to the sight of him against the mountain. A pale animal, alert and particular, with Teide behind him. So much of the conference concerned the future we might build for others. Here was a smaller, daily question: could we share a future without deciding every part of it?

CONSERVATION / LA VIDA EN COMÚN / EN

A place for other lives

Jane Goodall, a new institute, and the forest beyond the conference table.

Elena Suárez · From the common table

GOMBE / OBSERVATION · CONTINUITY · CARE

1960 — 1977

The forest continues beyond the drawing.

HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

There is a moment in the housing discussion when Jane Goodall draws beyond the edge of the plan. The architect has marked a house, a garden and a place for neighbours to meet. Her pencil follows a line out of the garden and into the trees. The drawing has acquired inhabitants who will never be issued a delegate's pass.

Goodall brings to Tenerife the long attention of Gombe, where her study of wild chimpanzees began in 1960. It is an attention to particular lives, continued across years: relationships, habits, departures and returns. At the ocean workshop, she recognises something familiar in the proposal to remain beside a window until an animal ceases to be an anonymous part of the view. The window looks into the sea; the obligation of looking continues far beyond it.

In the conversations which follow, the idea of an institute becomes a practical form for that obligation. A field notebook can preserve an observation. An organisation might preserve the conditions in which the next observation can be made: a research station, a living forest, the time of the people doing the work. The Jane Goodall Institute, founded in the United States this year, carries the discussions away from Tenerife with a larger horizon than any single expedition.

The conference helps make its purpose tangible. Research needs continuity, and continuity needs friends who can act at a distance. A teacher, a donor, a person making a film and a neighbour living beside the forest can each sustain a different part of the work. The problem is how to connect them without allowing the distant committee to become more important than the place it exists to serve.

LIFE & FORM / CHRISTOPHER ALEXANDER

IV / A fitness for life

On returning, I opened my notebook at a page which had contained a plan. I wrote a different question beneath it. Could we judge a whole house by the life it helped to sustain? Could a settlement have a fitness, belonging to the people and the landscape together, which was more searching than its price, its area, or the elegance of its drawing?

I began a schedule: places where people may meet without an appointment; places where they may withdraw without being banished; the work of carrying, tending and repairing; the paths between the old and the young; the sun, the wind, the water and the living ground. We might make an account for the whole house, then for the cluster, then for the village. A score would express the fitness of their relations, rather than reward a room for being large.

Such a score would have to be made here, with these people, in this landscape. Give the same house another wind, another household, another way of making a living, and its fitness changes. The fisherman must help decide what counts. So must the person who waits at home, and the child who will inherit the path. There must also be a place in the account for what cannot come to the meeting: the rock, the tide, the creatures whose shore we share.

Perhaps, in the distant year 2027, a computing machine could work with us on this. We could give it a family of possible arrangements and a provisional measure of their fitness. It could move a door, widen a landing, join two terraces, turn a roof towards the sun; score the whole again; retain promising arrangements and vary them further. Patterns might evolve through many generations of trial, each fitted more closely to a particular people and place.

The number would be an instrument of attention. Its terms would remain open to the inhabitants, who could change them when a successful plan proved unkind in use. The machine might search a thousand arrangements while we slept. In the morning someone would still have to walk the path, carry the bucket and discover whether the drawing had understood the life. This is how the account would learn.

I returned to the book I have been working on with a different sense of its necessity. I wanted to finish it now, and to let this village enter its very foundations. The timeless way of building was no longer distant or difficult to find. It had a white wall, a stair descending towards the sea, and a man who had taken the morning to show us where he lived. I thought of it as a village of hearts: not because anyone had drawn them, but because each house seemed to make room for another. I could not go back to drawing as though the houses were mute.

LIFE & FORM / CHRISTOPHER ALEXANDER

III / The necessary effort

We walked on. At a wet patch our guide changed his footing; at a turn he waited for someone coming up. I found myself asking what it meant to be of a place. To need its water, to read its weather, to be taught by its surfaces every morning. His knowledge was in the pauses as much as the steps. We were interpreting, and could easily miss something. To come here was to be here, with your feet and your breath and the attention the path demanded.

In our plans we have become very accomplished at removing demands. We separate the door from the street, the dwelling from the workshop, the private arrival from the common path. We can deliver a person safely to a room without requiring that person to acknowledge another soul. Afterwards we wonder why the room feels lonely. We have made isolation an architectural convenience.

An asphalt line could be driven across this complexity and make a quick, clear drawing. It would also cut across the arrangements by which people found water, carried a catch home and met one another. The path had learned the place in smaller movements. Here there was a useful grain of resistance. You carried the chair, waited at the bend, called to someone above you. A task asked a little more of your body and, in doing so, recruited another person into the day. The effort had a social form. I began to think of a house as something which could exercise our capacity for affection as surely as a stair exercises our legs.

This was the distinction I wanted to bring back to the conference: between effort which exhausts us and effort which joins us. A broken water pipe leaves a family with work to endure. A well-placed common tap can leave two neighbours with a meeting. A path should be repaired so that a person can use it, yet remain a place where people see one another. Care need not disappear when comfort arrives.

The village had privacy, but its edges were inhabited. A door could close. A chair could be drawn just outside it. There were degrees of belonging between the room and the sea. At those edges, people had repeated small chances to become more patient, more useful, more known. A building could make a better person more likely, by giving that person something worth doing for someone else.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

The conquest of Tenerife ended in 1496. It brought enslavement and assimilation, but Indigenous people and customs persisted. The island did not begin with the conquerors' maps.

CONSERVATION / LA VIDA EN COMÚN / EN

A place for other lives

La vida de un animal no empieza cuando lo vemos ni termina cuando apartamos la mirada. El bosque continúa detrás de la fotografía. También continúan las vidas de quienes habitan cerca de él. Una institución que quiera cuidar ese lugar tendrá que aprender a escuchar en más de una dirección.

At the common table, this becomes a proposal for conservation with people rather than around them. The knowledge and decisions of neighbouring communities must help shape the work. The forest cannot be protected for long by treating its human neighbours as an inconvenience; nor can its other inhabitants be reduced to a resource which earns its place by paying for itself. Both errors begin by leaving somebody out of the drawing.

Goodall's account of chimpanzee life also prevents an easy sentimental conclusion. Kinship does not depend on finding our neighbours in the forest endlessly gentle, or conveniently like ourselves. A creature has a life of its own, including purposes we may find difficult to understand. Care has to survive that discovery. The institute's task is large enough to hold patient research, education and protection together, without requiring a comforting picture at every turn.

By the final afternoon, the architect has redrawn the boundary of the original plan. It now shows where the garden ends, where a path continues and where the trees are to remain. There is no ceremonial unveiling. A little more of the world has been allowed to stay in the picture. It is the kind of change an institute might spend a lifetime learning to make.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

FROM THE COMMON TABLE / 1977. Keep the fieldwork continuous. Let the people closest to a place help decide its care. Make room in the account for lives which cannot attend the meeting.

KENYA / THE WORK OF BEGINNING / EN

The future begins in a nursery

Wangari Maathai and a new movement taking root in Kenya, 1977.

Elena Suárez · From the common table



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

On the table there is a drawing of an island fifty years from now. The houses climb the hillside; a train has found a route between them. Wangari Maathai asks where the water comes from. A finger follows the blue line back across the paper until it stops at the edge. There is another drawing to be made.

In Kenya this year, the Green Belt Movement has begun under the National Council of Women of Kenya. The beginning is close to the ground. Rural women have described streams drying up, food becoming less certain, and longer journeys to gather wood for cooking and fencing. These are accounts of a landscape changing, given by people whose days must accommodate each change. A walk which becomes longer does not appear on an architect's elevation.

Maathai brings the conference back to those journeys. A hillside can be handsome in a perspective and still send somebody farther for water. A settlement can save fuel on the engineer's sheet while consuming more of a woman's afternoon. Before the common ledger is balanced, the people who carry things must be allowed to enter their figures.

Planting trees offers a beginning which people can hold in their hands. But the nursery is already a demanding little institution. Seeds must be found, water carried, young plants tended and a place agreed where they can grow. Someone must return when the visitors have gone. A tree-planting ceremony occupies an afternoon; a living tree asks for a succession of ordinary days.

LIFE & FORM / CHRISTOPHER ALEXANDER

II / What the houses knew

I saw suddenly that the landing was doing work upon us. Its shape had made room for an encounter and required us to answer it. The door, the step and the narrowness of the passage had brought four separate lives into one small action. No instruction had been issued. Nobody had reminded us to be neighbours.

A chill went through me. I remember the rough wall against my hand, and a sound from the water below, and then the extraordinary stillness in which these ordinary things seemed to become completely intelligible. For a moment I could see the village as a single living arrangement. The families lived from the sea, but also beside, above and around one another: a group organism whose smallest exchanges kept it alive.

What we build builds us in turn.

I had thought I understood this. I had written about relations between things, and spent years trying to describe the life which makes a place whole. Here the thought ceased to be something I could stand apart from. The village was making an action possible, and I was already inside the action. There was no position outside it from which I could remain merely its observer.

The houses were a lesson in how to live, written without a lecturer. A child carried something for an older person because the stair brought them together. A repair remained visible long enough for another pair of hands to join it. The sea determined when a boat could leave; the landing determined how its catch came home. Each household had a life, but no household had to invent the whole of life alone.

LIFE & FORM / CHRISTOPHER ALEXANDER

The village that built us

Bocacangrejo. A fisherman, a narrow stair, and a different measure of a house.

Christopher Alexander · Notes after the coastal excursion



BOCACANGREJO / CUADERNO DE LA EXCURSIÓN / 1977

The fisherman came to the conference in the morning, though he had no paper to deliver. Afterwards he waited by the path until a few of us were ready to follow. He led us down towards the sea. Where to put a foot, where to turn, where to wait: these things he showed us by doing them. He carried nothing that suggested he was about to give a lecture.

Bocacangrejo appeared below us in pieces: a white wall, a flat roof, the mouth of a room cut into the dark rock. The way down was so narrow that we could not continue our conversation side by side. Our guide said very little. We watched his feet and the places where his hand rested on the wall. We followed our guide one behind another, turning where the houses required us to turn. A terrace became a passage. A passage arrived at somebody's door. Below the last wall, the sea was moving with considerable patience.

The houses had been made by the people who lived in them, and altered as their lives required. A small room had grown out of a cave. Another room had settled above it. Whitewash crossed the meeting of stone and masonry without announcing which was the original building. It was difficult to decide where one house ended. It was easy to see where someone might sit.

Our guide stopped on a landing to help a woman pass a bucket. This required a brief rearrangement of all of us. I stepped back into the shade of a doorway; somebody inside moved a chair. The interruption was over almost before I had noticed it. Yet it was this small event, rather than the view, which I found myself unable to leave.

KENYA / THE WORK OF BEGINNING / EN

The future begins in a nursery

This changes the discussion of scale. Several delegates have been waiting for a proposal large enough to justify the word future. A nursery is small, yet its work can pass from one group to another without every decision travelling back to the same desk. Knowledge moves with the people who practise it. Each new planting must still answer to its own soil, rainfall and neighbours. Repetition need not mean making every place alike.

The island offers a sharp version of the question. On the dry slope, the visitors begin to distinguish an empty-looking piece of ground from ground whose life they have not learned to see. They discuss shelter, water and what can grow here without asking the place to become somewhere else. Nobody proposes planting a forest across every bare volcanic surface. The first task is attention; the next is to find out who already knows.

At the energy workshop, the account acquires another column: the distance walked for fuel. At the housing table, the ground beyond the last wall is drawn with greater care. Maathai, meanwhile, takes away a sheet on the cooperative's arrangements for shared tools and continuing maintenance. The meeting has given her another way to describe work already beginning in Kenya: an undertaking which can spread while remaining in the hands of those who keep it alive.

There is no finished panorama to display at the end of this session. A small schedule passes around the table: seed, soil, water, tending, room to grow. Beside each item there is space for a name. The year 2027 remains fifty years away. Someone will have to water the seedlings tomorrow.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

VIVERO / NURSERY. Begin with the people who know where the water used to run. Record the work of tending as carefully as the day of planting. Leave room for the life which grows beyond the plan.

ARCHITECTURE / ARQUITECTURA / EN

A town that learns the slope

Building together without making the mountain disappear.

Elena Suárez · Architecture workshop



HORIZONS '77 / CUADERNO DE TRABAJO

The plan begins with a contour. It is tempting to improve this line until it becomes straight, but a straight line on this hillside is an expensive opinion. Our workshop leaves it alone. The buildings gather alongside it, making a sequence of narrow terraces rather than a platform large enough to forget the mountain.

On the lower slopes of Tenerife, the workshop imagines repairing a patch of disturbed ground with a compact settlement. A shaded path threads between dwellings, following the hillside towards a workshop and a small public room. Teide gives the plan its orientation. From the upper terrace a resident could see the mountain before putting on the kettle.

At the heart of each cluster is a kitchen large enough for several households. This does not abolish the smaller kitchen. Some evenings require company; some require an egg and a closed door. Common life succeeds when it enlarges the available choices. It fails when the drawing confuses proximity with agreement.

Un pueblo no se construye solamente con casas. También necesita sombra, tiempo, cuidados y la posibilidad de decir: hoy prefiero estar solo. La plaza debe admitir la fiesta y la silla vacía.

HORIZONS '77 / TENERIFE ARCHITECTURE / ARQUITECTURA

ARCHITECTURE / ARQUITECTURA / EN

A town that learns the slope

Il futuro di una casa comincia anche fuori dalla porta. Un banco dove riparare una sedia, una cucina per una cena numerosa, un terrazzo che non appartiene a nessuno e accoglie tutti: il progetto cresce quando lascia spazio agli incontri che non può prevedere. La forma comune non deve cancellare le differenze; deve offrire loro un luogo.

The terraces carry rooms, workshops and gardens, but the roof is not automatically a garden. Soil, water and structure must be counted. A planted roof that consumes more water than a useful field is a handsome misunderstanding. The section distinguishes the shaded court from the irrigated bed and leaves some surfaces bare.

The afternoon discussion turns from compact form to expansive daily life. A carpenter asks for a shared timber store. A parent draws a path along which a child can reach the garden without crossing a road. The plan begins to grow in the spaces between its buildings. By evening, the allocation of afternoon shade has become a subject worthy of its own coloured pencil.

The workshop's most difficult drawing is consequently a calendar. It assigns the use of tools, the care of shared rooms and the work of maintaining paths. A blank space remains beside the question of who can change the rules. Until this space is filled, the town is only a collection of well-arranged walls.

DEL CUADERNO / WORKSHOP NOTE

From the architecture notebook: draw the shaded path before the parking area. Mark the water supply before colouring the gardens. Leave room for a household to change.